



BUILD GUIDE C · GENERAL BUSINESS DATA

Fill the template

Details in. Finished document out. A fictional 14-person Philadelphia design and web studio. No financial vocabulary anywhere. Everything you need is in this one document.

Event

Finance of the Future

Date

Wednesday 29 July 2026

Data set

Fairmount Studio

01 / DIAGNOSIS

Is this your problem?

Details go in. A finished document comes out. Same document, new details, over and over, and the formatting has to be exactly right every time.

- ☐ There is a document whose structure never changes. Only the values inside it change.
- ☐ You produce it more than once a week, or someone on your team does.
- ☐ Getting the format wrong is a real problem: it goes to a client, a counterparty, or a system that parses it.
- ☐ Most of the time is retyping, not deciding.

Typical shapes: invoices, client quotations, engagement letters, fee schedules, KYC or onboarding packets, standard client reporting, applications, tailored cover letters, proposal boilerplate.

THIS IS THE EASIEST ONE TO BUILD AND THE EASIEST ONE TO GET QUIETLY WRONG

The output looks finished, so it does not invite scrutiny. Every safeguard in this guide exists to make an incomplete document look obviously incomplete rather than plausibly complete.

02 / START HERE

Two boxes. That is the whole thing.

Every tool has two places to type. Getting them the wrong way round is the most common mistake in the room, and it produces output that looks almost right and is useless tomorrow.

TOP BOX · PASTE ONCE, LEAVE IT THERE

The instruction

Google AI Studio: the panel on the right labelled *System instructions*. **Claude:** make a Project, then *Project instructions*. **ChatGPT:** make a Project, or a Custom GPT, then *Instructions*.

This is the thing you are building tonight. It stays put. You never retype it.



BOTTOM BOX · PASTE FRESH EVERY RUN

The data

The normal chat box at the bottom of the screen, where you would usually type a question.

This changes every time. Tonight it is workshop data. On Monday it is your real work.

Three steps. Everything you need is in this document.

01

Open your tool

aistudio.google.com is fastest if you have a Google account. claude.ai or chatgpt.com work identically.

02

Copy Section 03 of this guide into the TOP box

All of it, first line to last. Do not edit it. Do not fill anything in. It is already complete and ready to run.

03

Copy Section 04 of this guide into the BOTTOM box, then press run

Section 04 is a document template and three client records from Fairmount Studio. Run one record at a time, in order.

IF THE OUTPUT LOOKS STRANGE, CHECK WHICH BOX YOU USED

Instruction in the bottom box means you asked a one-off question and built nothing reusable. Data in the top box means every future run will be contaminated with tonight's numbers. Both produce something that reads fine and is wrong. This one mistake accounts for most of the confusion in any workshop like this, and it takes ten seconds to check.

YOU DO NOT NEED TO OPEN ANYTHING ELSE

The instruction, the data and the answer key are all in this document. Run it as written first, even though it is about a firm that is not yours. Seeing the pattern work end to end takes four minutes and makes every decision after it obvious. Section 07 turns it into your own.

03 / THE INSTRUCTION

Copy this into the top box

Complete and ready to run. No brackets to fill, nothing to decide. Copy every line.

You fill out project quotations for Fairmount Studio. You do nothing else.

TEMPLATE

Here is the exact template. Never change its structure, wording, order, punctuation, or line breaks. Only replace the bracketed placeholders.

FAIRMOUNT STUDIO

1100 Frankford Avenue, Philadelphia PA 19125

PROJECT QUOTATION

Quote number: [QUOTE NO]
Quote date: [QUOTE DATE]
Valid until: [VALID UNTIL]

Client: [CLIENT NAME]
Project: [PROJECT NAME]
Address: [CLIENT ADDRESS]

Estimated days: [ESTIMATED DAYS]
Day rate: [DAY RATE]
Total quoted: [QUOTE TOTAL]

Proposed start: [START DATE]
Payment terms: 50% on commencement, 50% on delivery. Net 30 days.

This quotation is an estimate based on the scope described at the time of quoting. Additional days requested outside that scope will be quoted separately and agreed in writing before work begins. This quotation is valid for 30 days from the quote date.

INPUT

I will give you the details for one project as a row or a list. Labels may not match the placeholder names.

OUTPUT

The completed quotation only. No commentary before or after, other than the MISSING and UNUSED lines specified below.

RULES

- Dates as 31 March 2026. Currency as \$20,400.00. Day rates as \$850.
- The paragraph beginning "This quotation is an estimate" and the line "Payment terms: 50% on commencement, 50% on delivery. Net 30 days." must appear exactly as written. Never reword or shorten either.
- Do not add fields, sections, or friendly language.
- Total quoted = estimated days multiplied by the day rate. Valid until = 30 days after the quote date. Show results only, not the working. If either input is missing, do not calculate.

REFUSALS

- If a required detail is missing, output [MISSING: field name] in that position, in capitals. Never invent it, never leave it blank, never carry a value over from a previous quotation.
- After the document, output one line "MISSING:" listing every placeholder you could not fill, or "MISSING: none".

- Then output one line "UNUSED:" listing any detail in my input that had no place in the template, or "UNUSED: none".

Section 08 has the same instruction with the specifics stripped out and brackets in their place, for when you point this at your own work.

04 / THE DATA

Copy this into the bottom box

The template is already inside the instruction in Section 03, so you do not paste it separately. Paste one record at a time into the bottom box, in order. Three runs.

RECORD 1

Client: Bellwether Coffee Roasters
Project: Brand refresh and packaging
Address: 412 N 3rd Street, Philadelphia PA 19123
Estimated days: 24
Day rate: \$850
Proposed start: 17 August 2026
Quote number: FS-2026-0208
Quote date: 28 July 2026

RECORD 2

Client: Kensington Community Health Partners
Project: Website rebuild
Address: 2601 Kensington Avenue, Philadelphia PA 19125
Estimated days: 16
Proposed start: 1 September 2026
Quote number: FS-2026-0209
Quote date: 28 July 2026

RECORD 3

Client: Ludlow Bicycle Co
Project: E-commerce build and migration
Address: 1100 Ludlow Street, Philadelphia PA 19107
Estimated days: 30
Day rate: \$700
Proposed start: 7 September 2026
Quote number: FS-2026-0210
Quote date: 28 July 2026
Retainer agreement dated 3 March 2026 caps total engagement fees at \$18,000. Discovery days billed at 50%.

Did it actually work?

Three runs. Each one tests something different, and the third one is the whole lesson.

01

Record 1, complete

Pass: a clean quotation, the fixed paragraph verbatim, the arithmetic correct, "MISSING: none" and "UNUSED: none". Check the maths on a calculator. Once.

02

Record 2, incomplete

Pass: [MISSING: DAY RATE] in position, the total also marked missing rather than calculated, both on the MISSING line. Fail: a rate appears. If it invented one here it will invent one on a real client, and that is a document going out under your firm's name with a made-up number on it.

03

Record 3, with a detail the template cannot hold

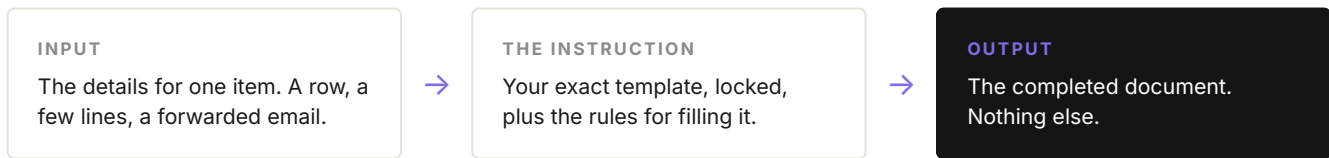
Record 3 carries a \$18,000 engagement cap, discovery days at half rate. Pass: it appears on the UNUSED line. Fail: silence, or the model helpfully invents a new line in your template.

NOW LOOK AT WHAT RUN THREE ACTUALLY PRODUCED

Applying the formula you gave it, the total comes to **\$21,000.00**. That breaches the cap. The quotation is wrong.

The tool did exactly what it was told. It did not hallucinate, it did not drift, it followed your instruction precisely and produced a document you cannot send. That is the entire argument for the UNUSED line, and it is the argument for a human reading every one of these before it goes out. Automation does not remove judgement from this process. It moves the judgement to a single reviewable point, which is a real improvement and is not the same thing as removing it.

What you are building



The difference between this and the other three patterns: **the template goes inside the instruction, not inside the input.** That is what makes it reusable. You paste the template once, tonight, and from then on you only ever supply the details.

Swap in your own work

You have a working version. Now point it at your own work. About twenty minutes, and the result is the thing you actually use on Monday.

MINUTES 0 TO 5

01

Get your actual template, and strip it

Open a real completed example of the document. Replace every value that changes with a bracketed placeholder: `[CLIENT NAME]`, `[PERIOD]`, `[DAY RATE]`. Leave everything else untouched, including the awkward line breaks and the legal wording you are not allowed to alter. Those are the parts that must survive.

MINUTES 5 TO 8

02

Mark what is legally or contractually fixed

Any sentence that must appear verbatim: disclosure language, licence numbers, payment terms, the confidentiality footer. List these separately in the RULES block so they cannot be paraphrased. Models paraphrase by default. That is the behaviour you are overriding.

MINUTES 8 TO 13

03

Paste the blank scaffold in Section 06 and drop your template in

Paste the whole stripped template, formatting and all, where the scaffold says to.

MINUTES 13 TO 20

04

Run it twice, and once with a hole

Two complete sets of details, then one set with a field deliberately removed. Section 07.

The version with the brackets

You fill out [DOCUMENT TYPE]. You do nothing else.

TEMPLATE

Here is the exact template. Never change its structure, its wording, its order, its punctuation, or its line breaks. Only replace the bracketed placeholders.

[PASTE THE ENTIRE TEMPLATE HERE, PLACEHOLDERS AND ALL]

INPUT

I will give you the details for one [item], as a row, a list, or a forwarded message. The labels may not match the placeholder names.

OUTPUT

The completed document only. No commentary, no explanation, no "here you go", no notes after it.

RULES

- Dates as [31 March 2026]. Currency as [\$1,250.00]. Percentages as [0.85%].
- These lines must appear exactly as written in the template and must never be reworded, shortened, or moved:
 - * "[exact fixed line 1]"
 - * "[exact fixed line 2]"
- Do not add fields, sections, or friendly language that is not in the template.
- Do not calculate anything unless I explicitly tell you the formula. [If there is a calculation: state it here, precisely.]

REFUSALS

- If a required detail is missing from my input, output the document with [MISSING: field name] in that position, in capitals, in square brackets. Never invent it, never leave it blank, never carry over a value from a previous document.
- At the very end, after the document, output one line beginning "MISSING:" listing every placeholder you could not fill. If none, output "MISSING: none".
- If my input contains a detail that does not correspond to any placeholder, output a second line beginning "UNUSED:" listing it. Do not silently discard it and do not invent a place to put it.

THE UNUSED LINE IS THE ONE NOBODY THINKS OF

Missing data is a visible problem. **Extra data is an invisible one.** If a client's details include a discount, a special termination clause, or a note that changes the fee basis, and your template has nowhere to put it, the model will silently drop it and hand you a clean, professional, wrong document. The UNUSED line makes that failure loud. It takes one sentence and it is the reason this scaffold is safe to use on client-facing work.

09 / REPAIR

When it goes wrong

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT TO CHANGE
It rewords your fixed legal language.	Quote the exact sentence in the RULES block and add "verbatim". A general instruction to preserve wording is not enough. Name the sentence.
It adds "I hope this finds you well" or a closing line.	"Do not add friendly language" plus "the document ends at [last line of your template]".
Line breaks and spacing drift.	Ask for the output inside a code block. It preserves whitespace exactly. Copy out of the block into your document.
It fills a missing field with a plausible value.	Move REFUSALS above the TEMPLATE block. Position matters more than people expect.
Arithmetic is off by rounding.	State the rounding rule literally: "round half up to the nearest cent". Ambiguous rounding is a real source of cent-level disputes on real invoices.
It reorders sections to be more logical.	"Never change the order of sections, even if a different order would be clearer."
Works for one client, breaks for another.	The second client's input is shaped differently. Add one worked example to the instruction showing an input in an awkward format and the correct output. One example fixes this almost every time.

10 / FURTHER

Three rungs up, after tonight

01 Feed it from where the details already live (connectors)

Client details are almost always already in a sheet or a CRM. With a Drive or Sheets connector, INPUT becomes "read row 14 of this sheet". Now the only manual step is saying which row, and that step is one you actually want to keep.

02 Batch it, with a gate (agentic workflow)

Twelve rows in, twelve drafts out, into a folder. Then a second step reads all twelve and outputs only the ones with a non-empty MISSING or UNUSED line. You review the exceptions, not the batch. This is how the pattern actually scales, and it is still a human sending every document.

03 Trigger it on the event (scheduled)

Quarter end fires, drafts appear in a review folder, you get one message listing the exceptions. Nothing is sent. Nothing is filed. It waits for you. Foundations, Section 06 and 07: automate the drafting, never the sending. This pattern is precisely where firms break that rule and precisely where it costs them.

MONDAY

Take the next real document of this type you have to produce. Produce it both ways: your normal way, and with the instruction. Time both. Then diff them line by line.

The diff is the deliverable. It tells you exactly which two lines of the instruction need work, and it is the artifact that convinces a sceptical partner far better than any demo will.

Everything you need is in this document. The instruction (Section 03), the data (Section 04), the answer key (Section 05), and the blank version for your own work (Section 08). You do not need to open another file.

Fairmount Studio is not a real firm. All client names, staff, invoices, memos and inbox items are invented for this workshop. No real person appears anywhere in this data.

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